1. Functions in Philosophy of Language and Speech-Acts

1.1. Functions

1.1.1. Seminar 1

What is the point of ascribing functions? What theoretical work are they supposed to do?

Are functional explanations and teleological explanations of the same kind?

Are functional explanations relative to explanatory interests?

What different kinds of accounts of function are there? Do they have the same explanatory aims?

1.1.2. Seminar 2

What are 'direct proper functions'? What are they supposed to explain?

What are 'Normal explanations'?

What are derived proper functions and what is their role in the theory?

What is the difference between the Generalized Selected Effects theory of function and Millikan's?

Are etiological theories of function too liberal in ascribing functions?

1.1.3. Seminar 3

What is the indeterminacy problem?

Why is the possibility of malfunctioning relevant for functional classification? Is an etiological approach necessary for explaining this possibility?

How do 'by'-relations help solve indeterminacy problems?

Why are vestigial traits a problem for etiological approaches?

Can etiological functions explain properly explain malfunctioning? Can systemic functions do so?

1.1.4. Seminar 4

Can the notion of function be thought of in terms of 'design'?

What is the difference between an 'initial presence' and a 'maintenance' view of etiological functions?

Does 'design' provide a way to unify other perspectives on function?

What distinguishes a 'recent history' view?

Are etiological functions and system functions notions which figure in different kinds of explanations?

Should we expect or aim for a unified theory of functions or accept pluralism about the notion?

1.1.5. Seminar 5

[In Millikan, the discussion on Gricean intentions is not of main importance for the course. Neither are the appendices of Ch. 4. For the Martinez paper, focus on the ideas of the argument and don't worry too much about the formalisms.]

What are stabilizing functions of language devices?

How do they relate to the 'literal use' of language devices?

What is the connection between a speaker's purpose of utterance and its function?

How do functions relate to meaning on Millikan's view?

How do teleosemantic approaches aim to provide a basis for representational views of meaning? Why might one be sceptical of such attempts?

1.1.6. Seminar 6

What sense of function is Sellars appealing to?

How does Sellars view lend itself to avoiding

What is an EMU and what theoretical work are they supposed to do?

What sense of function is Williams discussing?

Can inferential role be considered functionally?

Is Williams sketching a view of how to relate two different senses of 'linguistic function' to each other?

1.1.7. Seminar 7

What notions of function are Cappelen willing to entertain? How do they relate to the approaches we've looked at so far?

Why does Cappelen think that 'function' is a flawed notion for investigating language?

How does Thomasson answer that criticism? Is she successful?

How should we categorise Thomasson's notion of function?

Are functional considerations relevant for conceptual engineering/ethics? In which ways?

1.1.8. Seminar 8

What are the intuitions which support conventionalism and intentionalism about speech-acts?

Why might one be sceptical about the possibility that all speech-acts can be characterised in terms of conventions?

What resources are available to a conventionalist for responding to such criticism?

Which approach seems more promising?

1.1.9. Seminar 9:

How does Millikan analyse conventions? Does it relate to her views on function?

How does Millikan propose to bridge the gap between conventionalism and intentionalism?

What characterises 'co-operative proper functions'? Why does Millikan think that these characterise speech-acts?

How does communicative function relate to conversational score?

Are Murray and Starr using the same notion of function as Millikan? Does this generate a distinct kind of functionalism?

1.1.10. Seminar 10

Each of the readings suggests an analysis of a particular speech-act in terms of its function. In what sense of function are they best understood?

Is it plausible that these speech-acts have only a single function? If not, how does that interact with a functionalist approach to characterising speech-acts?

1.1.11. Functional analysis by Cummins (1975)

Functional analysis starts with Hempel and Nagel, sais Cummins. (A) The reason for functional characerization in science is to explain the presence of an item *i* in a system *s*. (B) For something to perform its function is for it to have certain function in *s*. Now we can say that presence of *i* in *s* characterized since *i* is present in *s* ***because*** it has certain effects on *s*. p. 741

Something is wrong, in particular with (A) above.

> An attempt to explain the presence of something by appeal to what it does—its function—is bound to leave unexplained why something else that does the same thing-a functional equivalent-isn't there instead. p. 745

References

Cummins, R., "Functional Analysis," *The Journal of Philosophy* **72**, pp. 741–760 (1975). https://doi.org/10.2307/2024640.